

STERILIZING WITH LIGHT

UV RADIATION

The light we see all around us is a form of energy called electromagnetic radiation. All radiation travels in waves, and most of these waves are too long or short to be seen by the human eye, such as ultraviolet (UV). UV is naturally produced by the Sun and other stars, but it can also be created on Earth using special lamps. These lamps have many uses, including disinfecting surfaces and revealing evidence in forensic investigations.

ELECTROMAGNETIC SPECTRUM

UV is one of many types of electromagnetic radiation, all of which can be imagined on a line called the electromagnetic spectrum. On the left side of the spectrum are waves with longer wavelengths (see page 184)—for example, radio waves. Visible light, at the center of the spectrum, is all the wavelengths that we can see with the naked eye. Types of radiation with shorter wavelengths, such as gamma rays, sit on the right side of the spectrum. UV radiation also has shorter wavelengths than visible light, and there are several different types of it.

